TABLEHISTORY

User Manual

A practical guide to cataloguing people, documents, and historical events and representing them on a timeline

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Desktop application for macOS and Windows

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License: GPLv3

Official GitHub repository

Introduction

This manual guides readers from their first launch of TableHistory through the creation of subject-based archives and the export of material that can be shared with others. It is intended for teachers, researchers, students of history, collection managers, and anyone who needs to compare events, people, and documents over time.

TableHistory helps represent a chronology, but it does not automatically verify the accuracy of the data. Dates, names, places, attributions, and sources still need to be checked. The best results come from combining clear records, consistent conventions, transparent notes, and regular reviews.

Menu names are given in English because the interface is currently available only in English.

1. What TableHistory is and who it is for

TableHistory is a free, open-source application for organizing historical records and visualizing their place in time using a Gantt-style chart. Records represent **people**, **documents**, or **events**. For each record, you can enter a name, a start year and an end year, whether either endpoint is uncertain, a place, and a free form note with basic formatting.

The grid lets you browse and sort items; the chart shows intervals, overlaps, and chronological sequences. For example, an archive about a cultural movement might contain authors, works, manifestos, and exhibitions: the list helps you check the data, while the chart reveals which items are contemporaneous and which belong to different phases.

TableHistory is suitable for timelines, document indexes, collective biographies, educational resources, local history, the history of science, and subject catalogues. Copying and pasting records between archives makes it possible to create subsets: a smaller collection can be extracted from a general archive for a research project, a lesson, or a PDF.

The program is not a precision calendar: the chart is based on years, while months, days, and times belong in the notes. It does not manage structured relationships between records, family trees, full bibliographies, or automatic source verification. You can mention other records, use tags, and insert links in notes, but these references are plain text and are not updated automatically when an item is renamed.

The simplicity of CSV files makes them easy to copy and preserve, but it also makes backups important. It is preferable to edit data through the application; editing a CSV directly in an external editor requires care with commas, quotation marks, and line breaks. For a reliable chronology, the quality of the information and the clarity of the conventions matter more than the number of rows.

The program is written in C++ using the Qt libraries and supports Windows and macOS. Data is saved in `.csv` files, so no separate database or server is required. The spell-checking for English, Italian, Spanish, German, French, and Portuguese, is provided by Hunspell (https://github.com/hunspell/hunspell). The project is distributed under the GPLv3 license.

2. The basic model: records, archive, and timeline

The basic unit is a **record** (*item*). A collection of records makes up an archive, usually stored in a CSV file. The main window has a grid on the left, a note-viewing area beneath the grid, and a Gantt chart on the right. Selecting a row lets you read its note and see where it sits in time.

The main grid and note panel are read-only, which helps prevent accidental changes. To create a record, use `Items - Add...`; to edit one, use `Items - Edit...` or double-click its row. Changes are made in a dedicated form and take effect when you confirm them.

The chart is a compact representation, not a replacement for the underlying data. A bar shows the record's year range; if an endpoint is marked as uncertain, the bar is displayed with a light pattern. The chart helps compare chronologies, but temporal proximity does not in itself demonstrate a causal relationship: interpretation should be explained in the notes and supported by sources.

Records are independent: there are no structured links that connect them automatically. This limitation makes it easier to copy selected items into a new archive without leaving broken references. To organize relationships, use consistent names, tags, and mentions in notes. Remember, however, that renaming a record does not update textual mentions of it in other notes.

For long-term projects, it is useful to maintain a master archive and create separate subject files, for example `European_History.csv`, `Renaissance.csv`, and `Printing_and_Books.csv`. Copying records lets you focus an analysis and share relevant data without distributing everything you have collected. Copies do not synchronize with each other: a correction in the master must be propagated manually, or the sub archive must be recreated.

3. Installation, first launch, and updates

Download the application from the official releases page: https://github.com/maxnd/TableHistory/releases/latest. Before installing, check your operating system and read the package notes.

macOS

The macOS package listed by the repository is built for Apple Silicon (M1 or later) and is not notarised by Apple. If macOS displays a warning, check that the package came from the official repository and follow Apple's instructions for opening an app that is not notarised. Use the following command after copying `TableHistory.app` to the Applications folder and checking the path:

```
xattr -r -d com.apple.quarantine /Applications/TableHistory.app
```

This command removes the quarantine attribute from the specified path. Do not run it on an application from an unknown source. If you are not familiar with Terminal, follow the graphical procedure documented by Apple instead.

Windows

Download the Windows package from the same official page and follow the instructions included with the release. The exact steps may depend on the package format provided. After the first launch, create a test archive, add a record, save it, and reopen it to check that the workflow works correctly.

Configuration files

The application saves these configuration files:

- *Windows* (System Registry): Path / Key: `HKEY_CURRENT_USER\Software\Massimo Nardello\TableHistory`
- *Windows*: `C:\Users\<YourUsername>\AppData\Local\Massimo Nardello\TableHistory\`
- *macOS* (Property List file): `~/Library/Preferences/Massimo Nardello/TableHistory.plist`
- *macOS*: `~/Library/Application Support/Massimo Nardello/TableHistory/`

Updating safely

Before replacing an application version, save and duplicate your important CSV files. Install the new release, open a copy of the archive, and check the grid, notes, and chart before continuing with the working file. Keep the previous copy until you have confirmed that everything works as expected.

The menu names in this manual remain in English. `File` deals with files and exports, `Items` with record management, and `View` with display options. Because keyboard combinations can vary between `Ctrl`, `Command`, and `Meta`, using the menus is often simplest when getting started.

4. Navigating the main window

The window is organized around three areas: **grid**, **notes**, and **chart**. The grid lists the records; the panel below it shows the note for the selected row; the chart on the right illustrates the time intervals. This layout lets you review structure and context without opening every record in a form.

Click a grid column heading to sort in ascending order; click again to reverse the order. Columns help group types, compare years, find items with the same place, or check names. Sorting changes how the list is displayed, not the stored data.

Notes in the main window are read-only. Web links in them are formatted as active hyperlinks; in the edit form, the text is instead prepared for easier editing without accidentally activating links. To change a note, open the record with `Items - Edit...`.

The chart can be zoomed in or out and scrolled. If it covers many centuries, start with a wide view and then zoom in on the period of interest. If a bar looks wrong, check the years in the record first: zoom changes the visual scale, not the record's chronology.

The three main menus are `File`, for creating, opening, saving, and exporting files; `Items`, for adding, editing, finding, selecting, copying, or deleting records; and `View`, for adjusting zoom and switching to full-screen mode. Before carrying out a bulk operation, check which file is open and which rows are selected.

5. Creating an archive and saving your work

Choose `File - New` to create an empty archive. Before entering a large amount of data, decide on the topic, the scope of the collection, and a naming convention. Names such as `History_of_Printing.csv` or `Town_1940-2000.csv` are more useful than `New.csv` or `Final2.csv`, because they remain recognizable months later.

Use `File - Open...` to open an existing CSV. After opening it, check the contents and make sure you did not select a similarly named copy. `File - Recent files` lets you open the last eight files used, but the list is no substitute for a clear folder structure.

`File - Save` saves changes to the current file; `File - Save As...` saves the work under a different name. Use the latter before a major reorganization, to create a variant, or to make a backup copy. To create a sub archive, copy the selected records into a new file instead of deleting irrelevant records from the master.

Before a file is saved, its existing version is copied as a backup file with the extension `.bak`. To restore data contained in this backup file, remove the `.bak` extension and open it with the app.

A broader backup strategy is to keep the working CSV, a dated copy, and another copy on a separate storage device or service. Make the copy after saving and, if possible, with the application closed. The frequency depends on the importance of the project: for an archive used every day, saving a copy at the end of each session may be reasonable.

Always distinguish three types of files: the complete **master**, subject-based **sub archives**, and **PDFs** intended for reading. A PDF does not replace the editable CSV; a sub archive must not be mistaken for the complete collection; and a backup should not be overwritten until you are sure the working file is intact.

6. The three record types

The `Kind` field indicates whether an item is `Person`, `Document`, or `Event`. The choice should reflect the role the record plays in your research, not merely the way the item is named.

Person

Use `Person` for a historical or contemporary individual: a politician, artist, scientist, author, witness, or participant in an event. In a biography, the start year normally represents birth and the end year death. For people who are still alive, the official AI format suggests repeating the birth year in both fields; the notes can state that the person was alive as of the last update.

If the goal is to study a cultural movement, the years might instead represent a person's period of activity rather than their entire life. This approach is possible, but the notes should explain it and the same convention should be used throughout the archive: do not mix life dates and years of activity without making the distinction clear.

Document

Use `Document` for books, letters, treaties, official records, manifestos, laws, manuscripts, editions, and other documentary sources. The title should be recognizable; where useful, include the author in the name according to a convention, such as `Author - Title` or `Title (Author)`. For a document dated to a single year, set the start and end years to the same value.

If drafting and publication took place in different years, decide which date to use in the chart and explain the others in the notes. Alternatively, you can create separate records for the document and the publication event if both perspectives matter to the project. Notes can retain summaries, provenance, editions, sources, and digital links.

Event

Use `Event` for individual episodes and processes: battles, reforms, conferences, migrations, discoveries, construction projects, crises, revolutions, or periods such as the Enlightenment. For a single event, the start and end years are the same; for a period, enter the chosen endpoints. The name should distinguish the event from similar episodes.

If the location is broad or includes several places, the `Place` field can contain the general area, and the note can list individual locations. Use a consistent convention, for example `City, Country`. A text place name is not the same as a geographic coordinate system.

Ambiguous cases and naming

A decree is generally a `Document`; its promulgation may be an `Event`. A person is a `Person`, while their reign may be represented as an `Event` if the political period is what matters. If both aspects are important, use two separate records and explain the relationship in the notes.

For people, choose one preferred form of the name and record aliases or variants in the notes. For documents, maintain a uniform structure. For events, add a place or other details to the name only when needed to avoid ambiguity. The best convention is one that is used consistently and understood by someone consulting the archive who does not know its creator.

7. Years, intervals, and uncertain dates

TableHistory covers years from **-20000 to 3000**, to cover also chronology for science fiction novels or climate change previsions. Negative years represent the B.C. period and, in recent versions, are displayed as B.C. in the chart; positive years represent the Common Era. For an event in 44 B.C., for example, enter `-44` in the year fields. When importing data, do not replace the negative number with a string such as `44 B.C.`.

The chart uses a yearly scale. Months, days, and times belong in the notes. If an event has an exact date, you can write `15 March 44 B.C.` in the note even though the time field contains only `-44`. A year range should follow the convention adopted for the record: a person's life, a period of activity, the duration of an event, or a chosen historical periodization.

Two flags, `StartUncertain` and `EndUncertain`, indicate whether the start or end point is uncertain. A bar in the chart is shown with a light pattern when an endpoint is marked as uncertain. The uncertainty should also be explained in the notes: for example, traditional dating, approximate year, conflicting sources, or disputed attribution. The pattern is a visual cue, not an automatic assessment of historical reliability.

To sort events from the same year by a more precise date, put the date at the beginning of the name and then sort by name. Use a consistent format: a four-digit year, a two-digit month and day, optionally followed by the time in two-digit hours and minutes. Examples:

- `B.C. 0044/03/15 • Assassination of Julius Caesar`
- `C.E. 1953/06/02 • Coronation of Elizabeth II`
- `C.E. 2001/09/11 08:46 • Morning event`

This is text-based sorting, not a dedicated date field: `2001/09/02` and `2001/10/01` are more reliable than inconsistent formats such as `2001/9/2`. Use this method only if day-level chronology is genuinely important.

For historical periods, choose the endpoints explicitly. The beginning of an era may vary by historiographical school or geographic area; record the adopted convention in the notes and distinguish conventional boundaries from documented facts. Apparent precision should not conceal a controversy.

8. Creating a record step by step

Choose `Items - Add...` to open the creation form. To modify an existing record, use `Items - Edit...` or double-click the row. Fill in the fields consistently and confirm only after checking the key details.

1. **Type and name.** Select `Person`, `Document`, or `Event`. Use a title that identifies the record without requiring the reader to open its notes.
2. **Start and end years.** Enter numeric years; use negative values for B.C. For an event that takes place within a single year, the two fields should match.
3. **Uncertainty.** Tick the flag for an uncertain endpoint and explain the reason in the note.
4. **Place.** Use a name consistent with the rest of the archive, such as `Bologna, Italy`, rather than alternating equivalent variants.
5. **Notes.** Begin with a summary, then add context, sources, and finer details.
6. **Review.** Check the title, years, and place; confirm with `OK` or `Meta / Ctrl + Return`.

At the bottom, there is a field for searching for a word within the text of the current note, along with `First` and `Next` buttons to highlight the first occurrence and subsequent ones. You can also specify the language for spell-checking or disable it by selecting the option `No spell-checking`.

Press `Esc` in the form to discard changes. After saving, check the grid row, the displayed note, and the bar in the chart. This quick review helps catch a missing minus sign, a reversed interval, or a flag enabled by mistake.

For example, an urban-history record could use `Kind = Event`, the name `Railway station opening`, start and end years of `1932`, and place `Bologna, Italy`. The note could contain the full date, the organising body, the context, and a link to a local archive. If you later discover that the official opening and the start of operations took place at different times, create two records or explain the distinction clearly in the note.

9. Writing and formatting notes

Notes are the flexible field of each record. They can contain summaries, context, short bibliographies, links, precise dates, transcriptions, open questions, and explanations of uncertainty. A useful note begins with what readers need to know, then adds the details they need to verify it.

In the `Add item` / `Edit item` form, the buttons above the editor let you apply level 1, 2, or 3 headings, bold, italics, or no formatting to the selected text. The documented shortcuts are:

Operation	macOS / Meta	Windows / Ctrl
Heading level 1	Meta + 1	Ctrl + 1
Heading level 2	Meta + 2	Ctrl + 2
Heading level 3	Meta + 3	Ctrl + 3
Bold	Meta + B	Ctrl + B
Italic	Meta + I	Ctrl + I
Remove formatting	Meta + 4	Ctrl + 4

After these buttons, there is a combo followed by two buttons, `Fill` and `Insert`. The button `Fill` fills the combo with all the existing tags in the file in use. To be recognized as such, each tag must be wrapped by two hash tags (#), have no spaces inside, and be contained in a single paragraph. The button `Insert` inserts the selected tag in the combo within the text of the current note at the position of the cursor. This functionality makes it possible to use coherently the same tags.

A long note can be organized into `Description`, `Dating`, `Context`, `Sources`, and `Observations`. You do not need every section in every record; the benefit is that a repeatable structure makes information easier to find. A short record may need only one paragraph, as long as its name and date are understandable.

To paste text from the clipboard without bringing over the source formatting, use the relevant command in the context menu or `Ctrl + Shift + V`. This is useful when copying material from a browser or word processor. After pasting, check that no page numbers, unrelated headers, or duplicated passages have been included.

Text size in the form can be adjusted with `Ctrl + Alt + +` and `Ctrl + Alt + -`. In the main window, the `View` menu provides note zoom.

In the main view, web links in notes are formatted and clickable. For an important source, do not store only the URL: record its title, responsible organization, access date, and the information used. A link may change or disappear; a readable bibliographic note helps identify the resource later.

Because there are no structured links between records, you can add tags to note text and later find them through search. Surround a tag with symbols, for example `#roman-history#`, to make searching more precise. Choose one spelling and avoid alternating between forms such as `#Rome#`, `#rome#`, and `#ancient-Rome#` if they refer to the same group. It is useful to distinguish subject tags (`#archaeology#`) from status tags (`#needs-review#`).

The AI format allows basic HTML in notes, such as `<b>`, `<i>`, and `<p>`, provided the CSV row is quoted correctly. If you do not want to edit CSV manually, the simplest approach is to request the official format and import it with `Items - Paste from selection`, then check the result in the editor.

10. Sorting, selecting, copying, pasting, and deleting

Click a column heading to sort in ascending order; click it again to reverse the order. For sorting by multiple fields, work backwards from the last priority. For example, to sort by type first and start year second, sort by year first and then by type.

You can select multiple rows using `Shift` or `Command`, depending on the selection operation, and select all with `Ctrl / Meta + A`. Before running a bulk operation, check the highlighted rows: the selection may be broader than expected, especially after a search.

`Items - Find...` searches for the first record containing the text in its name, place, or notes. `Items - Find next` and `Items - Find previous` move to subsequent or previous matches. To find all items containing a string, use `Items - Find and select...`: the command selects the results and can act as a temporary filter without permanently hiding all other rows.

Tags are useful for targeted searches. For example, adding `#local-history#` to the notes of relevant records lets search select the subset without confusing similar names or incidental occurrences of a word. For large groups, use a distinctive string and check the selection before copying or deleting.

`Items - Copy selected` copies the selected records to the clipboard. In the destination file, use `Items - Paste from selection` to insert them. The same command can import an AI block prepared with the expected header. Before pasting data into an important archive, test the process in a separate CSV file.

`Items - Delete` removes the selected records from the current file. If you want to create a smaller collection, it is safer to copy the relevant items into a new file than to delete unneeded items from the master. After a bulk operation, save and check the result; keep a backup before major clean-ups.

Search, selection, and copying make it possible to organize a modular archive. For example, in a master file called `History of Science`, select records tagged `#astronomy#`, copy them, and paste them into `Astronomy.csv`. The sub archive is independent, but future corrections to the master are not propagated automatically. Decide which file is the reference version and when copies should be recreated or updated.

11. Reading and adjusting the Gantt chart

The Gantt chart is the view that distinguishes TableHistory from a simple CSV list. It shows where the archive's items fall in time and helps reveal overlaps and intervals. It does not replace reading the records: it summarizes their temporal boundaries, while explanations and details remain in the notes.

11.1 Zoom and scrolling

The `View` menu includes `Zoom In Diagram`, `Zoom Out Diagram`, and `Reset Zoom Diagram`. Zooming in gives more visual space to the period displayed; zooming out shows a wider span. `Reset Zoom Diagram` restores the initial scale. There is also a zoom control at the bottom of the chart. You can scroll through the chart to explore the chronology.

For an overview spanning antiquity to the present day, begin with a scale wide enough to show many centuries. Then zoom in on a section to compare nearby events. If you are working only with a period of a few years, a very wide view may make differences look insignificant and labels harder to read.

11.2 Interpreting bars

The length of each bar reflects the recorded interval. A single-year event has identical endpoints; a person may cover a substantial part of the timeline; a historical period may span many years. A light pattern indicates an uncertain endpoint. If a bar does not match the expected chronology, return to the record and check the numeric fields: zoom does not change the underlying years.

Relative positions can raise useful questions: which documents are contemporary with a particular person? Which events precede a reform? How many generations overlap during a period? Temporal proximity, however, does not automatically prove causation. The chart shows co-existence or sequence; the interpretation must be argued in the notes and supported by sources.

11.3 Preparing the chart for an external reader

Before exporting, choose a zoom level that shows the relevant period without shrinking all the bars into unreadable marks. Check for out-of-range dates, overly generic names, and accidentally entered intervals. If the project spans a very long history, it may be better to export separate charts for different periods rather than force every detail into a single graphic.

The chart export uses a vector PDF with a white background, regardless of the operating system's light or dark theme. Vector graphics can be resized without the loss of sharpness typical of raster images. Even so, check the actual result, especially the readability of labels after placing the PDF in a presentation or larger document.

12. Exporting records and charts to PDF

TableHistory offers two main export functions for different purposes. `File - Export diagram...` exports the chronology chart as a vector PDF. `File - Export selected items...` creates a PDF document containing selected records. The second option asks for a title and prepares a summary of the items with their page numbers.

12.1 Exporting the chart

Use `File - Export diagram...` when you want to share a temporal overview—for a lesson, report, display panel, or comparison between periods. The exported chart has a white background, even when the interface is in dark mode. This makes the PDF suitable for printing and inserting into other documents.

The chart is vector-based, so it can be enlarged without becoming blurry. Vector quality does not solve layout problems, however: if the chronology is too dense, some elements will still look crowded. Adjust the zoom, divide the topic into subsets, and inspect the PDF before distributing it.

12.2 Exporting selected records

Select the items that should appear in the document in the grid, then use `File - Export selected items...`. Enter the title requested by the dialog. The resulting PDF includes an item summary and page references, allowing readers to locate records within the document.

This mode is suitable for a short catalogue, research appendix, handout, or subject booklet. Before exporting, check the selection and the quality of the notes. PDFs use fonts such as Helvetica Neue or Arial and have page numbers.

12.3 Checks before distribution

Open the PDF and verify that its title, pages, fonts, links, and content are readable. Make sure the notes do not contain internal comments that should not be shown to the public and that uncertain dates are explained. If the document will be printed, check readability at actual page size, not only at screen zoom.

Keep the CSV as the editable archive file; the PDF is the reading copy. If you correct a date after exporting, export the document again so it reflects the updated version.

13. Using AI to prepare data

It's possible to import items prepared with tools such as Google Gemini and Claude. The application should not be treated as a tool that independently verifies history: AI can suggest an initial set of records, but the information must be checked. The procedure requires a structured text block with a header and specific fields, not unrestricted prose.

13.1 Required format

The block must begin with the line `TableHistoryItems:` and then the following header:

```
Kind,Name,StartYear,StartUncertain,EndYear,EndUncertain,Place,Notes
```

Each record must be a single CSV row with eight fields. In the encoding specified by the documentation, `Event` is represented by the value `0`, `Document` by `1`, and `Person` by `2`. Years must be numeric; use negative numbers for B.C. dates. The two endpoints should be identical for a single-year event or document. For a person who is still alive, repeat the birth year in both time fields. Uncertainty flags must be `true` or `false`.

Enclose names and places in quotation marks when they contain spaces or commas, as shown in the official template. Notes containing commas, quotation marks, or formatting must be protected by valid CSV quoting. To avoid errors, do not ask an AI model for a Markdown table, bullet list, or JSON object: explicitly request the format shown here.

13.2 Starter prompt

The following prompt is an operational template in English based on the schema published in the repository. Replace the topic and requested quantity before sending it to an AI assistant:

```
Prepare 50 important records of people, events, and documents about [INSERT TOPIC]. Return a single
CSV code block, with no introductory text and no comments after the block. The first two lines must
be exactly:
TableHistoryItems:
Kind,Name,StartYear,StartUncertain,EndYear,EndUncertain,Place,Notes

Each record must be a single CSV row with the eight fields above in exactly the same order. Kind
must be 2 for Person, 1 for Document, and 0 for Event. StartYear and EndYear must be numbers; use
negative numbers for B.C. years. For a one-year event or document, use the same year for start and
end. For a person who is still alive, repeat the birth year in StartYear and EndYear.
StartUncertain and EndUncertain must be true or false. Quote fields correctly if they contain
commas or quotation marks. Notes must contain a summary in English, explain the dating where
useful, and include verifiable sources or URLs when available. Do not invent bibliographic
references; identify uncertain or unverified details in Notes. Avoid duplicates and keep names and
places consistent.
```

For broad topics, 50 rows can already be a lot to verify; for a first test, request 5 or 10. Once the format works and the records are correct, generate a larger collection. Do not simultaneously request an enormous quantity, very long notes, and specialist-level precision: it is often more effective to split the work into subtopics and then combine the results.

13.3 Importing the block

After receiving the response, copy the code block and use `Items - Paste from selection`. The official documentation identifies this command for importing records. Before using the entire block in an existing archive, test it in a new file or a copy. Check several records from each type: at least one person, one document, one single-year event, one period, and one record with a negative year.

If the years are wrong, names appear in the wrong fields, or notes are truncated, do not proceed with a larger import. Correct the prompt and test again. The import function follows the schema; it cannot know whether an event has been assigned the correct year or whether two documents are duplicates.

13.4 Verifying AI-generated data

The review should check at least: whether names exist and are spelled correctly; dates; negative values for B.C.; suitable record types; the distinction between point dates and intervals; consistency of the place field; whether URLs are relevant; and whether controversies are indicated. For historical work, it is important to read the source cited by the model, not merely confirm that the link exists.

One useful technique is to ask the AI for a separate short list of uncertain points. Even then, record only verified data and notes that clearly distinguish hypotheses from facts. If you keep a provisional record, add a tag such as `#needs-review#` and search for that tag periodically to complete the review.

13.5 Generating data for the master archive and subject archives

To build a large collection, request separate sets: one for people, one for documents, and one for events; or a series organized by period or geographic area. Twenty well-scoped items are easier to check than 200 heterogeneous ones. Once imported, use search and tags to identify duplicates, records without sources, and items outside the project's scope.

AI is most useful as an accelerator for guided research, not as a substitute for human judgement. The value of the archive comes from selecting, verifying, and explaining the items, not simply from the number of rows.

14. Recommended workflow

For a small project, it is enough to create a file, add records, and save. For an archive that will grow over time, use a regular six-stage process.

1. **Define the question.** Decide what you want to understand: a timeline of events, a source collection, a collective biography, or the history of a place.
2. **Set conventions.** Decide how to name records, how to use negative years, what a person's time interval represents, and which tags to use.
3. **Collect records.** Enter data manually or use a structured AI block. Work in small batches rather than focusing only on quantity.
4. **Check and complete.** Verify years, uncertainty, places, notes, and sources. Use tags to make items that still need review easy to find.
5. **Create a subject view.** Use `Find and select...` to search for tags or terms, copy relevant records into a separate archive, and adjust the chart.
6. **Publish and preserve.** Export a PDF, open it, and read it again. Keep both the CSV and PDF, then create a backup of the working file.

A record should be considered ready to share when a reader unfamiliar with the project can understand what it represents, why it is placed in that year, and where the information can be checked. The appropriate level of detail depends on the intended use: an introductory lesson needs concise notes, while a research catalogue may require more precise references.

15. Guided use cases

The following cases are examples of methods, not historical archives that have already been verified. They show how to organize records and use search, selection, and the chart to answer different questions.

15.1 Preparing a lesson on the French Revolution

Create an archive named `French_Revolution.csv` and include relevant people, political documents, and major events. Use `Person` for key figures, `Document` for declarations and acts, and `Event` for assemblies, uprisings, reforms, and institutional transitions. In the notes, distinguish the date of a document from the date of the event that produced it.

Add the tag `#french-revolution#` to all central records. Sort by start year and inspect the chart to see which processes overlap. For a lesson focused on a single year, use `Find and select...` to make a narrower selection and copy it to a short archive. Export the chart for the presentation and the selected records as a handout with definitions and sources.

15.2 Reconstructing the history of a town

For a city's history, use `Place` consistently, for example `Bologna, Italy`, or a more specific location if the project concerns a neighborhood. Records may cover urban development, administrative documents, people associated with civic life, and periods of change. Notes can preserve the municipal archive reference, collection/fonds information, and links to digitized resources.

When the archive grows, use `Find and select...` for the city name or a neighborhood tag. Copy the selection into `Historic_Centre.csv` or `Infrastructure.csv` to produce more focused chronology PDFs. Do not delete records from the master merely because they are not needed in a sub archive.

15.3 Cataloguing an artistic movement

For an artistic movement, record individuals as `Person`, works or manifestos as `Document` when the record focuses on the documentary object, and events—exhibitions, group foundations, or manifesto publications—as `Event`. Decide in advance whether the years for people represent their lives or their period of artistic activity; do not mix these meanings without explanation.

Notes can include style, major works, influences, and museum sources. A tag such as `#art-movement#` connects the collection at the text-search level. The chart helps show which artists worked at the same time and which exhibitions fall within the same phases, but it does not by itself prove artistic influence; that must be argued in the records.

15.4 Organizing a collection of family documents

TableHistory can serve as a chronological index of family documents: letters, textually described photographs, certificates, contracts, and memoirs. Use `Document` for the documentary item and identify in `Place` where it was created or is held, according to an explicit convention. In the notes, record the reference number, owner or archive, digitization status, and contextual information.

If the date is approximate, use the uncertainty flags and explain the method. Do not include sensitive personal details in a PDF intended to circulate without first considering who will read it. A family archive shared with relatives may need a reduced public version, made by copying only appropriate records into a new file.

15.5 Comparing scientific discoveries and publications

For a history-of-science timeline, use `Event` for discoveries or demonstrations, `Document` for articles and books, and `Person` for researchers. The document name should distinguish its title from the publication date and any later reprint. In the notes, state whether the date refers to the discovery, public announcement, publication, or later recognition.

Sort first by year and then by type to compare results with publications more easily. For a finer chronology of releases within the same year, follow the convention described in Section 7 of placing a date at the start of the name. This method is still text-based, so consistency and review are essential.

15.6 Creating a catalogue of literary works

A literary archive may include authors, works, first editions, journals, manifestos, and awards. Decide how to represent people and works: a `Person` record may describe a life or literary activity; a `Document` record may represent the work; and an `Event` may represent a publication or literary gathering. This distinction prevents a record from carrying two different temporal meanings.

Use a consistent naming format for works, such as `Author - Title`, and record the first-edition year, translations, or title variants in the notes. Tags such as `#poetry#`, `#novel#`, and `#first-edition#` let you create focused collections. Sub archives can become course handouts or indexes.

15.7 Preparing a museum route

For an exhibition, the archive can bring together documentary objects, historical figures, and events that contextualize a collection. Each note should have a summary suitable for the public and, when needed, a second, more specialized level with sources and conservation information. If final captions will differ from internal notes, prepare a sub archive containing only records approved for publication.

The chart shows the temporal context of the objects, while the PDF of records can be used for editorial review. Before distributing the material, check names, attributions, and rights for any externally referenced images; TableHistory does not independently manage rights or museum-loan systems.

15.8 Building a subject collection with AI

A researcher can ask an AI model to suggest 10 records on a subtopic, import them into a test file, and check the structure and fields. After review, relevant records can be copied into the master archive or kept in a subject file. If the model produces duplicates, names and search can help identify them; if a date is disputed, notes and uncertainty flags can indicate that the work is not complete.

The most reliable process is iterative: generate a small set, verify sources, import it, review the chart, and then integrate the next set. Importing a huge block at once saves clicks only if the structure is already correct; otherwise, it increases the number of errors to repair.

15.9 Preparing a timeline for a presentation

Create a file containing only the records needed for the presentation's question. Use understandable names, notes that are not unnecessarily long, and a chart adjusted to the period being discussed. Export the chart to PDF and the selected records as a supporting booklet. Before presenting, make sure the PDF opens on the presentation computer and that the type remains readable on screen or in print.

To avoid overloading a slide, do not necessarily use the entire archive. A general chart may be accompanied by a second export focused on the central section. Selection should support an argument, not merely demonstrate that many data points have been collected.

16. Quality control and good practices

The quality of an archive depends above all on consistency. Correct data placed in the wrong field can confuse the reader; an accurate note paired with an incorrect year can produce a misleading bar; a tag spelled in several ways can make a selection incomplete. It is therefore worth setting aside time for regular checks.

Before declaring an archive ready, check:

- that each record has the appropriate type;
- that years are within the allowed range and are negative for B.C. dates;
- that identical start and end years are intentional;
- that uncertain endpoints are flagged and explained in notes;
- that place names and personal names follow consistent conventions;
- that notes distinguish verified facts from hypotheses and cite sources that can be consulted;
- that tags are always spelled the same way;
- that exported PDFs have been opened and reviewed;
- that an up-to-date backup of the CSV exists.

16.1 Avoiding excessive detail in the chart

The chart should not contain every piece of information available: its purpose is to make temporal comparisons readable. The documented year fields cannot represent granularity finer than a year, so more precise details belong in the notes. If a chronology looks too crowded, reduce the number of records, create subsets, or export different views instead of trying to fit every detail into one chart.

16.2 Separating facts, hypotheses, and interpretations

In notes, use wording that makes the degree of certainty explicit. `The source documents` is different from `it is believed that`; `according to traditional chronology` is different from `a date confirmed by a contemporary document`. This precision improves educational use and reduces the risk of an editorial choice being mistaken for an undisputed fact.

16.3 Shared archives

A CSV file can be shared with other users through ordinary file-transfer methods. This does not mean that TableHistory provides built-in simultaneous collaboration, edit locking, or conflict resolution. If several people work on a project, agree on who updates the master, how copies are handed over, and how changes are consolidated.

If each collaborator edits an independent copy of the same CSV, the application does not reconcile the differences automatically. Before combining changes, compare the records and decide which version to keep. For a simple editorial collaboration, one person responsible for the master file and a review process for contributions may be enough.

17. Troubleshooting

A B.C. year is displayed incorrectly

Check that the field contains a negative number rather than the text `44 B.C.`. If the numeric value is correct but the display does not match the description, check the application version and the file that is open.

The timeline bar is longer or shorter than expected

Open the record and check the start and end years. Also verify whether the archive represents a person's life or only their period of activity, and whether the endpoints were entered according to that convention. The chart reflects the record fields; it does not correct dates based on the item's name.

The PDF looks crowded or is hard to read

Adjust the chart zoom, narrow the selection, or create separate exports for different periods or topics. For a PDF of records, select only the entries you need and shorten notes that are not relevant to the audience. Open the PDF before sending or printing it.

AI data goes into the wrong fields or a note looks incomplete

Check the CSV format, the eight-field header, quotation marks, and internal commas. The response must begin with `TableHistoryItems:` and the expected header row. Test with five records in a new file, correct the prompt, and only then import a larger set.

I cannot find a record I know I added

Try `Items - Find...` with a distinctive part of the name, place, or a phrase in the notes. To move through matches, use `Find next` and `Find previous`. Also check that the correct file is open and that you have not opened a similarly named copy.

I selected too many records

Stop before running a command and review the selection. If your goal is to export or copy a subset, repeat the search with a more specific term or use a complete tag. Do not delete records from the master to simulate a filter; create a sub archive containing the desired records.

I edited the wrong file

If the work has not been saved, consider discarding the changes. If it has been saved already, compare the file with the latest backup. Do not overwrite the backup until you have established which version contains the correct data.

18. Frequently asked questions

Is TableHistory free? Yes. The repository publishes it as free and open-source software under the GPLv3 license. For distribution, modification, or reuse of the code, consult the license text included in the repository.

Does the app use a database? No. Data is stored in CSV files. This makes copying and archiving easy, but requires a good backup routine.

Can I enter months and days in the chart? The time fields are annual. More precise details belong in the notes; to sort events from the same year, you can cautiously use the text-based convention of putting the date at the beginning of the name.

Can I link a person to all the documents they wrote? There is no structured linking feature between records. You can mention other items in notes, use tags, and adopt naming conventions; these references are not updated automatically when a record changes.

Can I create a smaller archive from a large one? Yes. Search for and select the records you need, copy them with `Items - Copy selected`, create or open the destination file, and use `Items - Paste from selection`.

Can the chart be exported to PDF? Yes, with `File - Export diagram...`. The PDF is vector-based and has a white background. To export records as a document, use `File - Export selected items...`.

Is data produced by Gemini or Claude verified? No. AI can prepare rows in the required format, but names, dates, places, sources, and duplicates must be checked by a person.

Is the interface available in Italian? The repository documentation for the version described here says the interface is available only in English. This manual therefore keeps the original menu names.

What does a light-patterned bar mean? It indicates that at least one endpoint has been marked as uncertain. The historical reason for the uncertainty should be explained in the note.

19. Glossary and quick reference

Archive: The collection of records contained in a CSV file.

Record / item: An entry representing a person, document, or event.

Kind: The record type: `Person`, `Document`, or `Event`.

StartYear / EndYear: The start and end years used in the chart.

StartUncertain / EndUncertain: Flags marking uncertainty about the start or end point.

Notes: Free-text field for description, context, sources, and links.

Grid: The list of records on the left side of the window.

Gantt chart: A bar-based timeline displayed on the right side.

Tag: A text label included in a note to find groups of records.

Sub archive: A separate file created by copying a group of records from the master.

CSV: A tabular text format in which fields are separated and, when necessary, enclosed in quotation marks.

Menu quick reference

Menu command	Main purpose
File - New	Create a new archive
File - Open...	Open an existing CSV
File - Save	Save the current file
File - Save As...	Save a copy under a new name
File - Recent files	Open one of the last eight files used
File - Export diagram...	Export the chart as a vector PDF
File - Export selected items...	Export selected records to PDF
Items - Add...	Create a record
Items - Edit...	Edit the selected record
Items - Delete	Delete the selected records
Items - Find...	Search for the first occurrence of text
Items - Find next/previous	Move between matches
Items - Find and select...	Select every matching item
Items - Copy selected	Copy selected records
Items - Paste from selection	Paste copied records or import structured data
View - Zoom In Diagram	Zoom in on the chart
View - Zoom Out Diagram	Zoom out on the chart
View - Reset Zoom Diagram	Restore the chart's zoom level
View - Zoom In Notes	Enlarge note text in the main view

Menu command	Main purpose
View - Zoom Out Notes	Reduce note text in the main view
View - Enter full screen	Use the window in full-screen mode

Most useful shortcuts in the edit form

Shortcut	Operation
Meta / Ctrl + 1	Heading level 1
Meta / Ctrl + 2	Heading level 2
Meta / Ctrl + 3	Heading level 3
Meta / Ctrl + B	Bold
Meta / Ctrl + I	Italic
Meta / Ctrl + 4	Remove formatting
Ctrl + Shift + V	Paste plain text into the form
Meta / Ctrl + Return	Confirm and close the form
Esc	Discard changes in the form

20. Conclusion

TableHistory is effective when used for what it is: an archive of time-based records, a grid for browsing and checking data, a chart for seeing periods and events in chronological relation, and two PDF export tools for sharing results. Its simple structure does not prevent large collections; it does, however, require clear editorial conventions, regular saving, and careful review.

To get started, create a small archive with a few people, documents, and events. Experiment with manual entry, uncertainty flags, search, selection, and export. Later, tags and sub archives can help manage more complex projects. AI can speed up the initial collection, provided that the CSV format is followed and every significant item is verified.

The most important rule remains this: the chart helps ask questions and communicate a chronology, but the scientific or educational value of the result depends on accurate records and transparent statements about sources, conventions, and uncertainty.

Official sources and further reading

- TableHistory repository: https://github.com/maxnd/TableHistory
- Project README: https://github.com/maxnd/TableHistory/blob/main/README.md
- Latest available release: https://github.com/maxnd/TableHistory/releases/latest
- Project wiki, with illustrated introduction: https://github.com/maxnd/TableHistory/wiki
- Introductory podcast: https://github.com/maxnd/TableHistory/raw/main/podcast/Introducing_TableHistory.mp3
- Advanced podcast: https://github.com/maxnd/TableHistory/raw/main/podcast/Advanced_TableHistory.mp3
- GPLv3 license in the repository: https://github.com/maxnd/TableHistory/blob/main/LICENSE

Appendix A. Complete example and final checklist

This example record is **fictional** and is intended only to demonstrate how to fill in the fields consistently; it should not be interpreted as a real historical fact.

Kind: Event

Name: Opening of the municipal bridge

StartYear: 1984

StartUncertain: false

EndYear: 1984

EndUncertain: false

Place: Borgonuovo, Italy

Example notes

Description. Opening of the municipal bridge to the public, as part of a project to connect the two banks of the river.

Dating. The year field records 1984. If the full opening date is verified later, enter it here without changing the annual resolution of the chart.

Context. Record the name of the sponsoring authority, the purpose of the construction, and any preparatory works. If the date of opening to traffic differs from the official ceremony, distinguish them clearly and consider whether two records are needed.

Sources. Add the reference to the municipal archive, the administrative resolution, or the local newspaper consulted. For a web page, record its title and URL; do not leave only a link without explaining which information it confirms.

This record is useful because each element has a clear role: the type states what the record represents, the name identifies the event, the years determine its position in the chart, the place provides a location, and the notes explain context and information provenance. In a real archive, replace the sample text with verified data and consult the cited sources directly.

Quick check before delivery

Before sharing an archive or PDF, carry out a final review from beginning to end. Open the correct CSV, choose some records from the beginning, middle, and end, and check that the main fields are consistent. Search for review tags such as `#needs-review#` and decide whether to complete, document, or exclude provisional records. Check that place names follow the same convention and that B.C. dates use negative numbers.

Next, inspect the chart at two scales: an overview to make sure the full-time span looks plausible, and a closer view to read a selection of bars. Uncertain dates should be flagged consistently and explained in the notes. The chart is a summary: if the history is complex, accompany it with a written explanation rather than relying on the image alone.

Before exporting, select only records intended for public release. Review each PDF for its title, page numbers, font size, notes, and links, and retain the source CSV plus a backup. For future updates, record the version or export date in the project metadata.

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